Abstract

Cultural heritage sights such as museums and public archives serve as producers of cultural memory as much as they preserve it. Exploring the archive not as housing fixed relics but as in flux we can see how the past can be brought into conversation with the present with varying motivations and interpretations and modalities. I will be using the British Film Institute (BFI) archive to explore the archive as curating cultural memory and creating the ability for re-framing and contextualization. A national film archive allows for the subversion, and (re)creation of alternative narratives to emerge out of old. As moving images have become increasingly produced and consumed they are increasingly influential for our understanding of the world, culture and our identities.

By collecting, preserving and making accessible, the national film archive plays a fundamental role in shaping our view of the past and our present. … "the archivist has become a curator in the process of selection, exhibition and recontextualisation of film heritage, even more so in the digital era. Memories, however, are not inherent in the archival stock, but are created in the context of reception, through processes of remediation and recontextualisation."[1] How does the meaning of a film migrate in relation to time and context when framed within the archive? I am interested in the special characteristics of the film archive as a liminal space between fiction and non-fiction and also of the past and future.

Key-words:

Re-Framing, National Film Archives, Cultural Heritage, Re-Mediation, National Memory

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[1] Brunow, Dagmar. *Curating Access to Audiovisual Heritage: Cultural Memory and Diversity in European Film Archives,* Image & Narrative Vol.18 NO.1: 2017, P. 2

Activating the National Film Archive

"The past cannot speak, except through its archive." Stuart Hall

Reframing the archive as an active space rather than passive allows for one to see that the archive is as much a producer of memory and narrative as it is a repository. A national film archive preserves, names, contextualizes and re-mediates (makes copies) of cultural heritage.What gets accepted into the national archive, how it is classified as well as what gets prioritized for digitization and by whom are all variables that contribute to the creation of cultural narratives in the present. Film is in motion, both in terms of thousands of frames being played at 24 or 30 frames per second, but also in its relationship to that which it documents. The film archive, specifically a national film archive is a depository of cultural memory: a place where histories are preserved and (re)created. The things it depicts are in flux: places, moments in time, people, animals and events are animated and un-fixed but are able to be *preserved* by film. I will be peering into the national film archive as a space in which to examine shifting meanings across place and time.

There seems to be an important distinction between the archive as an active space able to be approached and used and the archive as storage: archive as noun vs. archive as verb. However they are not separate properties they are one and the same, the archival practice of storage is as much about forgetting as it is about remembering. Conceptualizing the process of description and classification as constructing meaning, along with access, use and circulation transforms a stagnant repository into an active space where memory and narratives are in flux and in conversation with the present. Just like archiving, cultural memory is "an activity that is productive of stories and new social relations rather than merely preservative of legacies" [2] Preservation, and access are inevitably bound up with notions of power, those who decide what will be preserved and how it is classified and accessed.

Currently (December 2025) on the BFI film archives website we see a curation of films: *Black Britain on Film/ Britain on Film/ LGBTQ/ Animals on Film*[3] amongst several others. These categories have been named and created along with metadata that allows for groupings of these materials. These films can be

[2] Cesari, Chiara De and Rigney, Ann. *Media and Cultural Memory/ Medien und kulturelle Erinnerung,* VOL. 19, 2014:P.8
[3] BFI National Archive

accessed and explored via various platforms. This has involved 1) The initial creation of the work and acceptance into the archive 2) Creation of metadata 3) Decision to digitize these films 4) Decision to highlight and illuminate certain categories showcasing them on their website. When we explore *Black Britain on Film*, the subject tags on these films include, 'black people' 'racism' 'race relations'...What these subject classifications have done is allow the construction of a vast curation of films that include black people, and made visible works made by British black artists with films dating as far back as 1910. Examining one film in particular allows for us to examine with specificity the ways in which contextualization of materials and creation of key-words has changed the narrative, thus altering the visibility of the film and its meaning.

Springtime in an English Village: A Case Study

Springtime in an English Village, 7m: 1944
BFI identifier: 291096
Credits: *Colonial Film Unit*
Cast: No Cast Information Available
Subjects: *Cotswolds, Mayday Celebrations, Villages, Black People*
"Unseen for years due to the fragility of the materials, 'Springtime in an English Village' offers an extraordinary and unexpected snapshot of rural life in wartime. After a fairly predictable opening - farmers ploughing fields, cute baby animals gambolling - it finally gets down to business. The film is about that most ancient of English traditions: the selection and crowning of the Queen of the May. But what is so surprising is that the village of Stanion in Northamptonshire chose to honour a young black girl - apparently the daughter of an African merchant seaman who had been evacuated there during the War. It's hard to know quite how literally to take the proceedings. The film was made by the Colonial Film Unit

for the purpose of screening throughout Britain's African and Caribbean colonies - to demonstrate 'typical' life in the UK - at a time when the government needed to recruit the support of men and women from across the Empire. Later, in the immediate post-War period, such films not only acted to reinforce imperial solidarity, but formed part of a propaganda campaign to attract cheap labour to the UK."[4]

**In the U.S. one can view the film Springtime in an English Village here via the BFI's Youtube channel*

This is the description of the film that is provided in its metadata. This contextualization would not be transparent from the subject tags, nor the title of the film: *Springtime in an English Village,* Key-words, *Cotswolds, Mayday Celebrations, Villages, Black People.* This film has been re-framed and curated, placing it in a greater context of colonial history and the use of film to advertise British Life to the colonies in order to attract cheap labor. How was this film categorized previously, what language and metadata was included? Knowing when this description was created, and how it was previously described and embedded with meaning would provide a more transparent and deeper framework for understanding cultural heritage narratives. Labels deduce cultures/ objects/ people into a set of controlled keywords, they flatten and objectify. In regards to the *mi* archive the very act of doing so is objectifying culture and peoples. Who is being labeled and by whom? Is there consent?

The Role of The National Film Archive

A national film archive is a cultural memory institution: a generator and repository. Created as a keep-safe for holdings that reflect the breadth of British moving image contributions across the world of cinema and to establish and promote access to these collections. The BFI National Archive is a mostly publicly funded archive that originated in 1935 promoting the use of film to record contemporary life, customs and manners: in short to promote film as a way to save and preserve national identity, heritage and culture. Its key aim as a public archive is to be permanent and to persist through time. The BFI National Archive is part of the British Film Institute which is funded by the National Lottery, government grants from the Department of Digital, Culture, Media and Sport as well as British Film Institute Act 1949, as well as its own commercial activities such ticket sales, dvd sales and other avenues of revenue. The fact that it is a national, publicly funded institution has directly affected the choices they make in their data management systems and archival operations. For simplicity I will be referring to the BFI Film Archive as the BFI, or the archive.

[4] BFI catalogue, *Springtime in an English Village,* 7m: 1944, BFI identifier: 291096

These cultural memory or *heritage* institutions have an inherent power bias that has been prominent since their creation. Classifying and collecting materials of culture, has objectified peoples and cultures usually without their consent and with incredible bias and ignorance. Naming things, labeling things and putting them into classification systems has been a huge part of the colonial and imperialist enterprise. The information attached to a material of cultural heritage thus has an immense amount of power: having a category and naming something in a cataloging system, allows for the invisible to be made visible. When we are speaking about under-represented groups, or appalling moments in a nation's history, language and context become incredibly important appendages to materials in the archive. Labels and names can harm and hide, but can also bring people into focus that have been marginalized, as well as moments in a nation's history it would rather forget be made visible. Data/ Metadata become powerful players in the archive, as well as digitization, access and permissions for use.

Materiality

The BFI holds over 800,000 *mi* (moving image) works, millions of paper materials, and over 80,000 books. The mi collection includes Analog and Digital formats, including 8mm, 16mm, Super 16mm, 28mm (a rare mostly home movie format),35mm (including nitrate prints), 68mm, 70mm and Imax (for traditional large format IMAX). Digital and Video Formats include HD cam and HDcam SR, Digibeta and Betacam SO (PAL/NTSC), Blu-Ray and DVD, and Digital Files (MP3, AIFF and WAV) amongst others. Digital and Analog both exist physically in an archive "there is no such thing as immaterial digital film. A digital film is as material as any other object; it is stored on a material carrier, projected through a material digital projector, and screened on a material screen or viewed through a device (computer, tablet, or smartphone)."[5]

The colossal amount of material being held (and constantly created) means a robust and comprehensive collections management system. Film, digital and analog takes an incredible amount of energy (physical/ electrical) as well as space (physical and digital). The BFI does not use cloud computing but keeps everything *in-house* with no reliance on google, or other third parties to hold their materials. As a public national archive this is something that they have been intentional about: not wanting to rely on a private sector company to hold their materials. One can see both ethical as well as technical reasons why relying on the cloud for a national archive is problematic. When thinking about using the cloud Stephen McConnachie archivist at the BFI stated " it was difficult to enter into an agreement with a cloud provider that would give you certainty about where your files were being stored, which legal territory. The BFI

[5] Fossati, Giovanna's 2001 [1st Edition] seminal book on film archives: *Grain to Pixel,* which specifically references the BFI,[2018]: P.19

National Archive stores the moving image collection on behalf of the British nation. We don't own the rights – it's not a commercial exercise. We had to guarantee that the national collection is stored in the UK." [6] Technically and physically film files can be as large as two terabytes each, so when thinking about digesting tens of thousands of files, this would require incredibly powerful bandwidths, and in reference to the cloud this doesn't just mean a lot of money but also a vast amount of time.
The public funding of the archive thus directly affects the thinking behind their ethical and technical choices behind their system and methodology for archiving, the "aim of a public archive is to be permanent and to persist through time"[7] Thus having things as much under their control without reliance on outside private sources seems rational, why should public funds be going straight into the private sector, and what guarantee would there be that the materials would be protected in perpetuity. One can see that the archive must be making incredible choices as they approach what films to prioritize for digitization, and what categories of films to name and bring attention to as they face the millions of hours of footage in their holdings.

The Archivist's Role: Classification Schemas, Metadata/ Classification and Labeling
With over 800,000 *mi* works, millions of documents and thousands of books one can understand the need for a comprehensive cataloging schema that is expandable and practical for storage and use. There are various schemas used in film archives (*SAD, FIAF, EN 15907, AMIM and PBCore),* but they all follow the same or similar best practices outlined by FIAF (International Federation of Film Archives)[8]. Each record generally provides title, year of release, location, production company, credits, cast, synopsis (if available), subject terms, references, and technical information where copies are held, with most names, companies and articles hyperlinked, as well as the various manifestations that exist of each work.

One can see both referential and hierarchical modalities at play in the BFI's Collection's Information Database (CID). The BFI's CID employs various metadata standards, but the primary standard they use for moving image work is EN 15907 (Cinematographic Works Standard). The EN 15907 data standard is a three-level hierarchical model for describing *mi* works which is a widely adopted standard among film heritage archives. One can see that this schema uses FRBR (Functional Requirements for Bibliographic Records) as its conceptual framework. The hierarchy is: Work < Manifestation < Item

Additionally the materials in the catalog can be viewed in a relational schema, with hyperlinks and keywords that direct you to related works, with subjects, genres, peoples, dates and materials all

[6] Stephen McConnachie, [2019]. Archivist at the BF interviewed by Feed Magazine Interview
[7] Stephen McConnachie, [2019]. Archivist at the BF interviewed by Feed Magazine Interview
[8] FIAF cataloguing manual

becoming variables that one can explore in relation to one-another. This use of keywords or tags is one of the ways in which items in the archive are brought together, and brought into the light: as other searchable properties do not allow for subjects or categories to be clustered and made into linkable-referential entities. This means that the key-words chosen are incredibly powerful in their ability to curate and manifest meaning, as well as choosing what narratives to make visible and which to obscure. Through metadata one is creating meaning, producing linkages and similarities, creating categories and classifications: Film A can be seen as in conversation with Film B/ or Films A and B include groups of people representing X. As an archivist one is actively taking part in determining the importance of a work, and deciding how the material will be classified, how and what narratives will be preserved. In addition to the footage itself, the information that is created to accompany a work becomes incredibly powerful in its ability to highlight or pacify facets of history and culture.The lines are thin, labels and categories risk essentializing or othering under-represented or minority groups. This gives the archivist a powerful role in the production of national memory and narrative.

"Data," Rosenberg writes, "has no truth."13 Such assumptions about data are based on similar concepts about the objectivity of facts and truth in the sciences. Yet data is constructed and are historical; they are not transparent or self-evident[9]

What films get chosen in the process of digitization, what research is done to collect data, what data is chosen to be entered, what language is used, what categories are omitted? Each one of these has an incredible influence on the production of the archive and what is manifested. The metadata of each entry allows for classification, categorization and cataloging. Metadata makes something searchable and findable: bringing the otherwise inaccessible and invisible into plain sight. Key-words and tags, in the public archive in promoting or hiding cultural narratives. In creating a subject tag, or naming a place or person one can find previously invisible/ or hidden materials, peoples and places being made visible, thus entering public consciousness and becoming included in the nation's cultural memory. In relation to representation and cultural heritage Stuart Hall states "It follows that those who cannot see themselves reflected in its mirror cannot properly 'belong'"[10]. The national archive becomes a site of exclusion and irrelevance for minority/ under-represented groups, not a passive container holding established narratives of national history.

Digitization and Duplication: Accessibility and Creative Reuse

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[9] Turner, Hannah: 2020, P.14
[10] Hall, Stuart: 2002, P. 75

The ability for films to be digitized and duplicated gives them the ability to be circulated more widely, as well as to be re-mediated, re-used and re-contextualized. This potentiality of the format of film transforms it from a storage container into working memory. Just like archiving, cultural memory is "an activity that is productive of stories and new social relations rather than merely preservative of legacies"[11]
The ability to scan film to create analog and or digital copies poses both challenges and possibilities for film archives[12]. Practices of film to film copying, photochemical preservation, scanning, telecine and digitization allow for accessibility, restoration and preservation- whilst simultaneously bringing up copyright and ethical use issues. Digitization is used to a) restore film, b) digitization is a way of creating digital versions of analogue films, such as 35mm or 16mm film gauge, which can then be screened in today's cinemas (as digital projectors increasingly replace analog ones) and c) digitization allows films to be remediated and recontextualised. Films that would otherwise be obscure if not invisible become easily accessible and visible. One can see that then the decision of what films to prioritize for digitization and or film to film duplication are political and powerful choices an archivist/or an archive makes. Digitization and the ability to duplicate allows for multiplicity: endless copies can be created and (re)cycled allowing for the re-classification of narratives: this is unique to the quality of the moving image, upending notions of ownership and fixed classification.

The ability to duplicate and publish materials brings up other issues for the archive: Who gives permission for these materials to be exhibited and re-appropriated? A lot of the materials in the BFI's collection are government sponsored films such as *Springtime in an English Village,* which was sponsored by the government and produced by their *Colonial Films Unit.* Does the unnamed main subject of the film, the young girl in the film give consent, can she, is she still even alive? None of these answers are easy or one case fits all. In terms of ethics to do with using archival footage, the relationship of the artist/ creator to the footage is a factor, as well as the new context it is going to be used in.

Conclusion

The archive as a creator of meaning and cultural heritage sets it in motion. Cultural heritage is being negotiated and defined by the structure of the archive, the economics that fuel it, as well as the technological tools at its disposal. The archive is gate-keeper but also creator of access, without it there would be no repository to sift through, and no access to permit. Derrida explores the archive as creating, as much as it forgets. Viewing the archive as a process rather than static, stable and objective acknowledges that the archive is an agent in the production of knowledge and information. The archive is

[11] De Cesari, Chiara, & Rigney, Ann: 2015, P.8
[12] Fossati: 2009 as well as Wengström: 2013

active[13]: constantly remembering and forgetting. The national archive mediates memory through the narratives it projects.

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[13] Derrida, *Archive Fever,* One of the classic pieces that promoted the archive itself as a subject of study, not merely a place to study and do research on a given topic

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Reframing, Repairing, & Repatriating

Reflections on Group Project: Jacob Welch, Jacquelyn Melillo, Olivia Taussig-Rees

We each approached our subject through different material and subjectivity. Jacob explored physical artefacts, Jacquelyn explored photographs and I explored Moving Image formats.

I focused on re-framing the archive as an active space rather than a static memory vault. I did this by focusing on film, specifically the BFI Film Archive. I was really focusing on the construction of national memory and what *cultural heritage* sights embody and what they create. Apart from my slides and the topic I covered, I wrote the first introductory slide with the Stuart Hall quote for our presentation, wanting to give a general context for the conversations and topics we would each cover in our presentations.

We generally all worked together on the presentation, I feel that Jacob and I worked well together and shaping our presentation, by deciding the general arc and flow of the piece. We discussed as a group the order in which we would each discuss our topics during the presentation, considering which subjects would flow best into the next. I would say that my participation in the project was mostly represented by my particular subject of Re-Framing, and it's contributions to the topics we were exploring. I was an active participant, initiating certain meetings, and raising particular questions.